

11.1 Why Network?

Do you have more than one computer at home? If you do, how often have you moved from one system to another just to copy files or print documents? While copying files from one system to another, how many times have you cursed corrupt floppies or CDs? You probably have also found yourself waiting for the system that has the Internet connection to be vacated by the family member using it, just so you can check mail. It's time you set up a home network, and because you're running Windows XP, it's going to be easier than ever to do so!

11.2 Required Hardware

Before you get your hands dirty (since you haven't cleaned your system in a long time) you need to make sure you have all the necessary things needed to network your systems. There are two options available to connect your PCs: wired or wireless networks. A wired network is really cheap to set up, and gives you excellent data transfer rates. However, the positioning of your systems is pretty much fixed, and you're going to have ugly white or grey wires running wild in your home. For those who want a better-looking setup, or those who have laptops as their personal computers, a wireless network is probably a much better idea. With a wireless network (using Wi-Fi) data is transmitted at the 2.4 GHz frequency.

Before you begin, make sure you have a LAN (Local Area Network) card. There are two types of LAN cards available in the market: the most common type, the internal LAN card, connects to a PCI slot on your motherboard, while the external option connects to a USB port on your system. The internal models are a lot cheaper though, so you would probably want to opt for these. Many newer motherboards come with an onboard LAN port, so there might be no need to buy a LAN card separately.

Once you've set up the LAN cards, or found the LAN slots on